

SEO vs Google Ads vs Pay-Per-Move: What's Best When You're Just Starting?

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You've got a truck, a crew, and a license. Now you need customers. The question every new moving company owner faces is: where do I spend my limited marketing budget to get the fastest, most profitable return?

Here's the honest comparison — no vendor bias, real numbers.

Channel 1: SEO

SEO means ranking in Google's organic search for terms like "movers [your city]" or "moving company near me."

How long it takes: 4 to 9 months to see meaningful traffic in most local markets. Competitive metros: 12 to 18 months.

What it costs: DIY: \$100 to \$300/month. Agency: \$750 to \$2,500/month.

The brutal truth for new operators: SEO cannot pay your truck payment next month. It's a long-term asset. An operator who bets everything on SEO at launch will have a beautiful website and zero revenue for 6 months.

Best for: Building the long-term foundation while other channels generate near-term revenue.

Channel 2: Google Ads

Puts you at the top of search results immediately. You pay per click.

2026 CPCs for moving company terms:

Market Type	CPC Range	Cost Per Lead (8% CVR)	Cost Per Job (45% close)
Major metro (NYC, LA, Miami)	\$15 – \$45	\$188 – \$563	\$418 – \$1,250
Mid-size city (Denver, Nashville)	\$10 – \$28	\$125 – \$350	\$278 – \$778
Smaller markets / suburban	\$6 – \$18	\$75 – \$225	\$167 – \$500

Major metro numbers are challenging — you can spend \$500 to acquire a \$700 job. In smaller markets, the economics are much better.

What makes it work: Dedicated landing page with pricing, photos, and reviews. Answering calls within 2 to 3 minutes. Strong review count. Reviews on the landing page improve CVR by 20 to 40%.

Best for: Exclusive, high-intent leads once your foundation (reviews) is in place.

Channel 3: Pay-Per-Move

You pay a success fee only when a move is completed. Zero upfront cost.

Economics:

- Typical success fee: 10 to 15% of job revenue
- On an \$800 job: \$80 to \$120 cost
- Marketing cost as % of revenue: 10 to 15%

- Risk: Zero — you pay only after you're paid

Why it matters for new operators: When every dollar counts, zero-risk matters. Google Ads requires \$1,000 to \$1,500 in testing before it generates consistent jobs. An SEO retainer runs \$1,000+/month for months. Pay-per-move generates your first jobs within days with no front-loaded spend.

Best for: Immediate revenue, filling trucks during slow periods, generating cash flow while you build owned channels.

Channel 4: Lead Platforms

Shared leads at \$35 to \$80 each with 10 to 18% close rates. Cost per acquired job: \$195 to \$800. In a business where your average job is \$700 to \$900, that math rarely works.

Best for: Testing only. Not as a primary channel.

The Recommended Sequence

Month 1: Google Business Profile + review system + pay-per-move

Month 2 to 3: Add Google Ads (\$300 to \$600/month) once you have 8+ reviews

Month 3 to 6: Begin SEO investment

Month 6+: All three channels stacked and working together

This matches your cash flow reality at each stage. You're not spending \$2,000/month on SEO with \$0/month in revenue.

The NEPQ Question

If your only customer acquisition channel went away tomorrow — no more word-of-mouth, no more referrals, no more [whatever you're using] — where would your next job come from?

If you don't have a clear answer, that's the risk to solve.

Ready to start with zero risk? Book a free strategy call and let's talk about what pay-per-move looks like in your market.